



Sriram "Futsuu" Gurunathan
readersletters@thinkdigit.com

FIFA 11, despite bringing out a myriad of reactions from us, wasn't a significant enough upgrade over its predecessor to warrant a purchase, even if it was drastically different.

EA Sports has looked to change that with FIFA 12, as one might have noticed with all the pre-release "best FIFA ever" talk. We dismissed that as the perennial hype machine, but were we right to?

In their quest to get ever closer to realism, EA Sports has focused on a particular aspect of football each year. Two years ago, 360-degree dribbling was introduced, and last year it was the passing system that got a revamp. This year, it's the turn of the aspect that has stayed pretty much untouched for more than a decade now – defending.

Tactical Defending, as the feature is called, takes the focus away from pressing and closing down to a more positioning and timing-based system. This has been done via a change in the control scheme. The press button is now the contain button, which makes a defender try limiting a player's movements instead of homing in on his target. It obviously takes some getting used to, but defending becomes a very rewarding experience.

The game pace has been lowered too and that makes a huge impact on the next feature – Precision Dribbling. It aims to give you more control over how your player dribbles in close quarters and give players a lot more time on the ball, the lack of which was one of our primary complaints about previous editions of FIFA.

Our reaction to the new Impact Engine, which changes the way player model physics is handled, isn't as positive though. This addition hoped to redefine interaction between the players on the pitch which earlier depended on canned animations. It works pretty well for the most part, making collisions look quite painful, but on occasion ends up causing some unintentional laughter or rage with some pretty hilarious or unfortunate outcomes.

Offline game modes haven't changed much, with the Career Mode where you can take on the task of being a Player, a Player-Manager or a Manager and craft your career. Unfortunately, what has also not changed much is the fact that it's riddled with bugs.

Online mode carries a few minor changes, like having you select your team and difficulty level before searching for opponents, instead of the other way round.

Head-to-head is really broken because of a very unfortunate exploit which means we're pretty much facing the AI online, which is kind of stupid; if we wanted to do that, we'd just play offline.

Pros:

- » Tactical Defending is a great addition
- » Precision Dribbling gives players a lot more time on the ball
- » Nice, solid presentation

Cons:

- » Impact Engine is a bit wonky in places
- » Both Online and Offline game modes are plagued with bugs

Details:

Developer: EA Canada

Publisher: Electronic Arts

Genre: Sports/Football

Platforms: PC, Xbox 360, PlayStation 3

Also available on: Wii, PSP, 3DS,

iOS, Mac OS X, PlayStation 2,

PlayStation Vita, Xperia Play.

PEGI Rating: 3

Price: 999 (PC), 2,499 (Xbox 360, PlayStation 3)

Presentation is just what we've come to expect from EA Sports, though it hasn't changed much from FIFA 11. Alan Smith replaces Andy Gray as Martin Tyler's partner. Clive Tyldesley and Andy Townsend are also present as the voices for cup fixtures.

The Final Whistle

FIFA 12's gameplay is extremely solid and is only a few Impact Engine tweaks away from being excellent, but the numerous bugs and issues that plague the game are quite the mood killers. One can only hope patches are on the way, but we've seen EA Sports do this year after year, and there are no signs that lead us to believe that this year is any different.

The bottom line, though, is that FIFA 12 is a great game when you get on the pitch and actually play football. The off-the-pitch issues are what plague it most, which sort of makes it realistic and close to real-life, just not in a way EA Sports – and certainly not the way the fans – expected it to. *

Ratings:

- » Graphics: 8.0
- » Sound: 9.0
- » Gameplay: 9.0
- » Game Modes: 6.0
- » Value for Money: 7.0

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